Terms of Reference for Litigation Database - Legal Unit Hyprep

Project: Litigation & Case Management System (LCMS) for LEGAL UNIT HYPREP

Version: 1.0

Date: 2026-04-24

Contract Duration: 6 Months

1. Objective

The objective of this TOR is to describe functional requirements for the Litigation & Case Management System (LCMS) to be used by HYPREP's Legal Unit, external counsel, and administrators. The application will allow users to upload court processes and drafts, list filed/pending/concluded cases, schedule court dates per matter, and provide role-based dashboards and controls. The document will help development, QA, operations, and stakeholders agree on scope and acceptance criteria.

2 Scope

LCMS is a web-based application for managing litigation and case records in the Nigerian legal context. The Scope and Core capabilities include:

- Case creation, tracking and status management (filed/pending/concluded)
- Uploading and versioning of court processes, drafts, evidence and attachments
- Scheduling and managing court dates and hearing outcomes
- Role-based dashboards for Legal Unit staff, Admins, Super Admins and external counsel
- Notifications, reminders, audit trail, and reporting
- Security, backup, and compliance features suitable for legal records

3 Definitions, acronyms, and abbreviations

- LCMS — Litigation & Case Management System

- HYPREP — Hydrocarbon Pollution Remediation Project
- Admin — system administrator with user & configuration privileges
- Super Admin — top-level privileged role; can perform all admin tasks
- Legal Unit Staff — internal lawyers, paralegals, case officers
- Counsel — external lawyers
- CRUD — Create Read Update Delete
- SLA — Service Level Agreement

4. Product perspective

LCMS is a modular web application that will serve as the central repository for litigation matters and legal documents. It will follow a client-server architecture with a responsive single-page application (SPA) front-end and a RESTful backend API connected to a relational database. The product will integrate with email servers, SMS gateway (optional), and cloud file storage (or on-prem storage) for document retention.

5. Product functions (high-level)

- Secure login, multi-factor authentication (optional) and SSO (optional)
- Role-based access control
- Central case register and docket (case file)
- Document upload with metadata, OCR (optional) and versioning
- Court date scheduling with calendar views and reminders
- Task assignments and deadlines
- Search and advanced filter capabilities across cases & documents
- Audit logs, activity timelines, and reporting engine

6. User classes and characteristics

1. **Super Admin**
    - Full control: manage users, roles, system settings, data retention, backups, view audit logs.
2. **Admin**
    - Manage users (create, disable), manage cases, configure workflows, generate global reports.
3. **Legal Unit Staff (Lawyer, Senior Lawyer, Paralegal)**
    - Create and manage cases assigned to them, upload documents, schedule dates, add notes, assign tasks.
4. **Case Officer / Clerk**
    - Data entry, document uploads, serve as first-line for case updates and scheduling.
5. **External Counsel** (optional)
    - Restricted access to assigned case(s), upload drafts and processes, view hearing schedules.
6. **Read-only Stakeholder**
    - Non-editing access to selected cases and reports.

Operating environment

- Web browsers: Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari (latest two major versions)
- Mobile: Responsive mobile web; native apps out of scope for v
- Backend: Linux-based servers/containerized environment (Docker/Kubernetes optional
- Database: PostgreSQL (recommended) or MySQL
- File storage: S3-compatible object storage or on-prem NAS

- Authentication: OAuth2 / OpenID Connect or in-app user store

7. Design and implementation constraints

- Data protection and confidentiality of legal documents
- Nigerian legal terminology and date/time formats
- Integration constraints with third-party government e-filing systems (may require additional approvals)
- Regulatory/compliance constraints for retention and archiving of court documents

8. Authentication & Authorization

- System shall provide secure user authentication (username/password).
- System shall support Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) (optional/configurable).
- System shall support role-based access control (RBAC) with permissions mapped to roles (Super Admin, Admin, Legal Staff, Case Officer, External Counsel, Read-only).
- System shall support Single Sign-On (SSO) via SAML/OAuth2/OpenID Connect (optional).
- System shall lock a user account after configurable number of failed attempts and provide administrative unlock.

9. User & Role Management

- Admin/Super Admin shall create, edit, disable, and delete user accounts.
- System shall support bulk user import (CSV) with role assignment.
- System shall support user profile fields (name, title, department, phone, email, photo, practising license number).

- System shall allow assigning users to teams or departments and linking users to cases.

- System shall log user role changes with audit trail.

9. Case Records Management

- System shall allow authorized users to create a case record with metadata: Case ID, Title, Parties, Court, Case Number, Filing Date, Case Type, Matter Owner, Status, Priority, Value (if applicable), External Counsel, Notes.

- System shall automatically generate a unique Case ID and allow manual Case Reference.

- System shall support adding parties (plaintiff, defendant, respondents, appellants) and contact details.

- System shall support case cloning or template creation for recurring matter types.

- System shall allow linking related cases (e.g., appeals, related suits).

- System shall allow marking cases as Confidential/Restricted.

10. Document Management (Court processes, drafts)

- System shall allow upload of documents (PDF, DOCX, images) with metadata (document type, upload date, author, confidentiality flag, tags).

- System shall provide document versioning and retain historical versions.

- System shall allow previewing common document formats in the browser and in-line download.

- System shall support OCR for uploaded scanned documents (optional) and store searchable text.

- System shall enable document-level access control and watermarked downloads for confidential docs.

- System shall support bulk upload and drag-and-drop functionality.

- System shall support document check-in/check-out for collaborative editing.

11. Case Life-cycle & Status Tracking

- System shall maintain statuses: Draft, Filed, Pending, Adjourned, Heard, Judgment Delivered, Concluded, Closed, Archived.

- System shall allow authorized users to update case status and add status change reason and timestamp.

- System shall keep a case timeline (chronological activity feed): filings, uploads, court dates, tasks, notes, status changes.

12. Scheduling & Calendar (Court Dates)

- System shall allow adding scheduled court dates (hearing date, time, court room, judge, purpose) per case.

- System shall provide a calendar view (daily/weekly/monthly) filtered by user, team or court.

- The system shall automatically notify assigned users and external counsel of upcoming dates (configurable: e-mail/SMS/in-app reminders at 1 week, 3 days, 24 hours, configurable).

- System shall allow bulk scheduling of hearing blocks and import of court lists via CSV.

- System shall allow recording of hearing outcomes and next steps (adjourned to date, judgment, reserved judgment).

13. Task & Workflow Management

- System shall support task creation linked to cases (task owner, due date, priority, attachments, status).

- System shall provide workflow templates for common processes (e.g., filing, service, judgment enforcement).

- System shall enable assigning tasks to individuals or teams and send reminders.

14. Notifications & Alerts

- System shall send configurable notifications via email and in-app notifications for: new case, document upload, court date added/changed, task assigned, status changes.

- System shall support digest notifications (daily/weekly summary) and immediate alerts for high priority matters.

15. Search, Filter & Reporting

- System shall provide global search across cases, parties, documents, and tasks with full-text search.

- System shall provide advanced filters (case status, court, date range, owner, tags).

- System shall provide built-in reports and ad-hoc report builder (export to CSV/PDF).

- Reports required: caseload by status, upcoming hearings, age of matters, workload by lawyer, concluded matters summary, document inventory.

16. Dashboards & KPIs

- System shall provide personalized dashboards for each role displaying relevant KPIs (open cases, upcoming hearings, overdue tasks, high-priority matters).

- System shall provide administrative dashboard for system metrics (active users, storage consumption, system health).

17. Audit Logging & History

- System shall log all critical events (user login/logout, create/edit/delete of cases/documents, role changes, scheduling) with timestamp, user, and IP address.

- Audit logs must be queryable and exportable by Admin/Super Admin.

18. Data Import/Export & Integration

- System shall support importing historical case data and documents (CSV + associated file mapping).

- System shall support exporting case dossiers (PDF bundle) and bulk data exports (CSV/JSON).

- System shall provide RESTful API endpoints for case, document, user and scheduling data for integration with other HYPREP systems.

19. Administrative Features

- System shall support configurable case types, courts list, document types, status flow and tags.

- System shall provide role/permission editor for fine-grained access control.

- System shall provide storage/quota management and retention policy configuration.

20. Security Controls & Compliance

- System shall encrypt data at transit (TLS) and at rest (AES-256 or equivalent for sensitive documents).

- System shall provide role-based data access controls and document-level confidentiality flags.

- System shall support periodic password expiry and password strength rules (configurable).

- System shall support session timeout and device/session management for users.

21. Backup & Recovery

- System shall support automated backups of database and document store with configurable retention.

- System shall provide recovery procedures and RPO/RTO defined in operations runbook.

22. Performance

- The system shall respond to UI actions within 300ms (typical) for common queries; complex searches may take up to 3s.

- File upload throughput: support concurrent uploads (e.g., 30 concurrent users uploading 10–50MB files) without failure.

23. Scalability

- System shall scale horizontally (stateless application servers) and support database vertical/horizontal scaling as required.

24. Availability & Reliability

- Target availability: 99.5% (excluding scheduled maintenance).

- System shall perform graceful degradation: read-only mode if document store temporarily unavailable.

25. Usability & Accessibility

- UI shall follow usability best practices; typical task (create case and upload primary document) should take under 3 minutes for trained user.

- System shall follow WCAG 2.1 AA accessibility guidelines where reasonably practical.

26. Maintainability & Extensibility

- Codebase should be modular, follow industry best practices and include unit, integration and end-to-end tests.
- APIs should be versioned.

27. Localization

- System shall support Nigerian English formatting (dates dd/mm/yyyy or configurable) and local currencies where applicable.

28. Data Retention & Archiving

- System shall support archive/restore of concluded cases per configurable retention policy (e.g., archive after X years).

29. Logging & Monitoring

- System shall expose metrics for application health (response times, error rates) and integrate with monitoring/alerting tools.

30. Major Entities

- Users
- Roles & Permissions
- Cases (CaseFile)
- Parties

- Documents
- CourtDates (Hearing)
- Tasks
- Notes & Comments
- AuditLogs
- Teams/Departments

31. Sample ER model (textual)

- User 1..* -> Team
- User 1..* -> Case (as owner/assignee)
- Case 1..* -> Document
- Case 1..* -> CourtDate
- Case 1..* -> Task
- Document 1..* -> Version
- Case 0..* -> Case (related cases)

32 User Interfaces

- Responsive SPA (React, Vue or Angular) with role-specific dashboards and a consistent navigation: Cases, Documents, Calendar, Tasks, Reports, Admin.
- Document viewer modal, case timeline, in-app notifications center.

33 APIs (REST) & Integration Points

- Public/partner REST API endpoints (secured via OAuth2/JWT) for: GET/POST/PUT/DELETE Cases, Documents, Users, CourtDates, Tasks, Reports.

- Webhook support for external systems to receive event notifications.

34 Email/SMS gateways

- Integrate with SMTP server for email notifications and optionally with an SMS gateway (Twilio, Africa's Talking, etc.) for urgent alerts.

35 Third-party integrations

- Cloud storage (S3-compatible) or internal file server

- Optional integration with court e-filing portals or a future e-court integration layer

- Optional integration with identity providers (Azure AD, Google Workspace

36. Wireframes & UX Notes (high-level)

- Left navigation: Dashboard | Cases | Calendar | Documents | Tasks | Reports | Admin

- Case list: table with columns: Case ID, Title, Parties, Court, Owner, Status, Next Hearing, Actions

- Case detail: header with core metadata, tabs: Timeline, Documents, Court Dates, Tasks, Notes, Related Cases

- Document viewer: modal with metadata panel, version history, download/print

- Calendar: user/team views with drag-and-drop rescheduling

- Mobile: condensed list views, quick-add case/document

37. Security & Privacy Considerations

- Enforce least privilege—users only see cases they are assigned to or allowed to view.
- Use TLS 1.2+ for all transport.
- Encrypt sensitive files at rest; use signed URLs for downloads with expiration.
- Use secure storage of credentials and secrets (Vault or equivalent).
- Regular security patching and dependency scanning.
- GDPR-like principles for data minimization and retention; follow Nigerian data protection regulations (NDPR) as applicable.
- Session management: revoke tokens on password change or user disable.

38. Testing Requirements

- Unit tests for backend logic and components (target coverage > 70% initially).
- Integration tests for API endpoints.
- End-to-end (E2E) tests for core user journeys (case creation, document upload, scheduling).
- Security testing: static code analysis, dependency scanning, OWASP Top 10 checks, and penetration testing prior to production release.
- Performance testing: load tests simulating concurrent users and file uploads.
- Accessibility testing for key pages.

39. Deployment & Environment

- Environments: Development, QA/Staging, Production.

- CI/CD pipelines for automated build, test, and deployment (GitHub Actions/GitLab CI/Jenkins).
- Containerization (Docker) for consistent deploys; orchestration via Kubernetes (optional).
- Secrets management: environment variables or secrets store.
- Backups stored in secure, geographically separate locations.

40. Maintenance & Support

- SLA & support tiers to be agreed (e.g., business hours support, critical 24/7 on-call).
- Regular incremental releases & hotfix process.
- Runbooks for common operational issues (failed jobs, storage full, restore backup).

41. Acceptance Criteria

- System allows authenticated role-based access and creation of cases with unique Case IDs.
- Document upload, versioning and preview work for major formats.
- Court date scheduling creates calendar entries and notifications are received by assigned users.
- Admin panel allows user management and configuration of case types and courts.
- Export of case dossier yields complete PDF bundle that opens and contains indexed documents.